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Data and Tech Standards for Children's Social Care

Placement Standards Working Group Q1

March 2026

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Things to be aware of

Conflicts of interest – Please inform the chair / secretariat if you think there is a risk.

Anti-competitive activities – Please inform the chair / secretariat if you think there is a risk of anti-competitive activity.

Intellectual Property - If you are concerned about the use of your contributions, please contact the secretariat.

Meeting Recording - We will record this meeting and using AI transcription tools.

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Principles for group

1. Every voice matters
2. Please join in on the conversation, we don’t want this to be one way
3. If you’re happy to, keep your camera on
4. Please raise your hand if you want to come in, or drop your ideas in the chat
5. Respect the diverse viewpoints in the room, assume positive intent and remain open for different experiences

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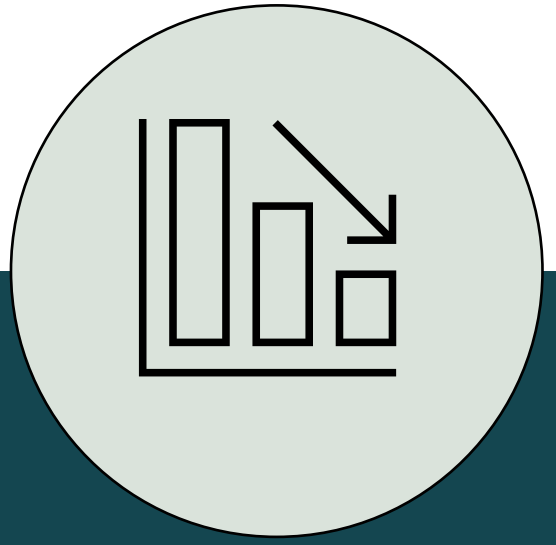
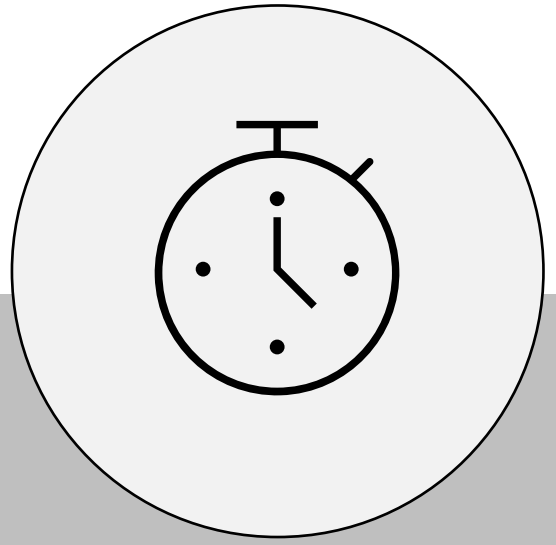
Reminder - Programme Overview

Programme Overview

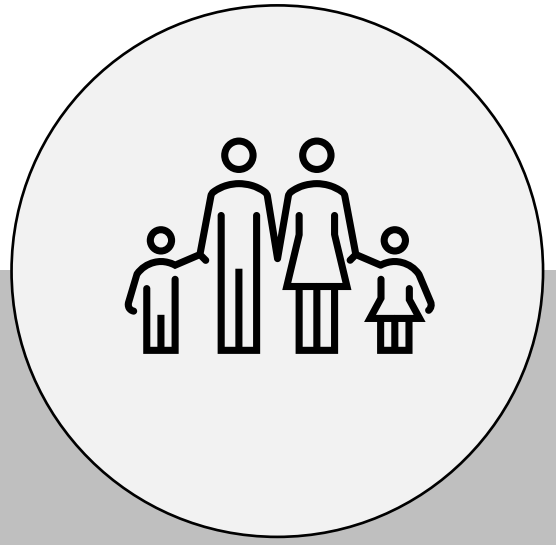
Improved data sharing to support safeguarding decisions



Better data analysis and strategic decision making



Improved productivity for social workers and a reduction in tech inhibiting processes



Increased power sharing with children and families

FOCUS FOR THIS GROUP

Last year - recap

2025	2026

Our WG terms of reference during this phase were to **design and launch** the first version of the standard

Now in 2026 the role of this WG will shift from design to overseeing **scaling** and maintaining **fidelity** of the live standard

Last year - recap

	2025						2026				2027	
	JUL	AUG	SEP	OCT	NOV	DEC	Q1	Q2	Q3	Q4	Q1	Q2
	Design and Development						Governance					
Working Group meets	●		●		●							
Deep Dives		●	●	●	●							

Last year, we developed a rhythm of **quarterly ‘full group’ meetings** to share updates and endorse key decisions or changes, with the **detailed work taking place in deep-dive sessions** outside this forum.

Last year - recap

	2025						2026				2027	
	JUL	AUG	SEP	OCT	NOV	DEC	Q1	Q2	Q3	Q4	Q1	Q2
	Design and Development						Governance					
Working Group meets	●		●		●							
Deep Dives		●	●	●	●							

Deep dives were where we made progress on detailed design choice

Last year - recap

	2025						2026				2027	
	JUL	AUG	SEP	OCT	NOV	DEC	Q1	Q2	Q3	Q4	Q1	Q2
	Design and Development						Governance					
Working Group meets	●		●		●							
Deep Dives		●	●	●	●							

Working Groups provided overall oversight of our design decisions

Agenda for today’s session

1. Reminder – what are we setting out to do?
2. Update on the pilots
3. Update on key design issues
4. Update on next steps and wider rollout.

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What type of organisation are you representing?

Central Govt	Local Authority	Regional group	IFA or Resi Care Provider	Tech or Software Supplier	VCSE	Other
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What is your role?

Social Worker / Principle SW	Data Analytics / Reporting / Performance	Data Management or Governance	Commissioner / Strategic Commissioner	Director / Leadership	System Change / System Transformation Lead	Other
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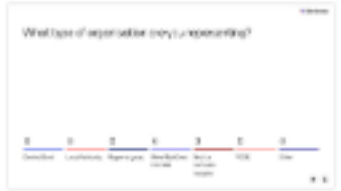
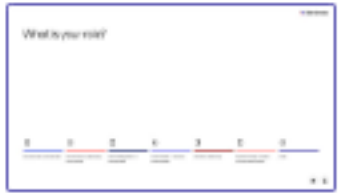
2026_Placement Stand...

Select which slide to add

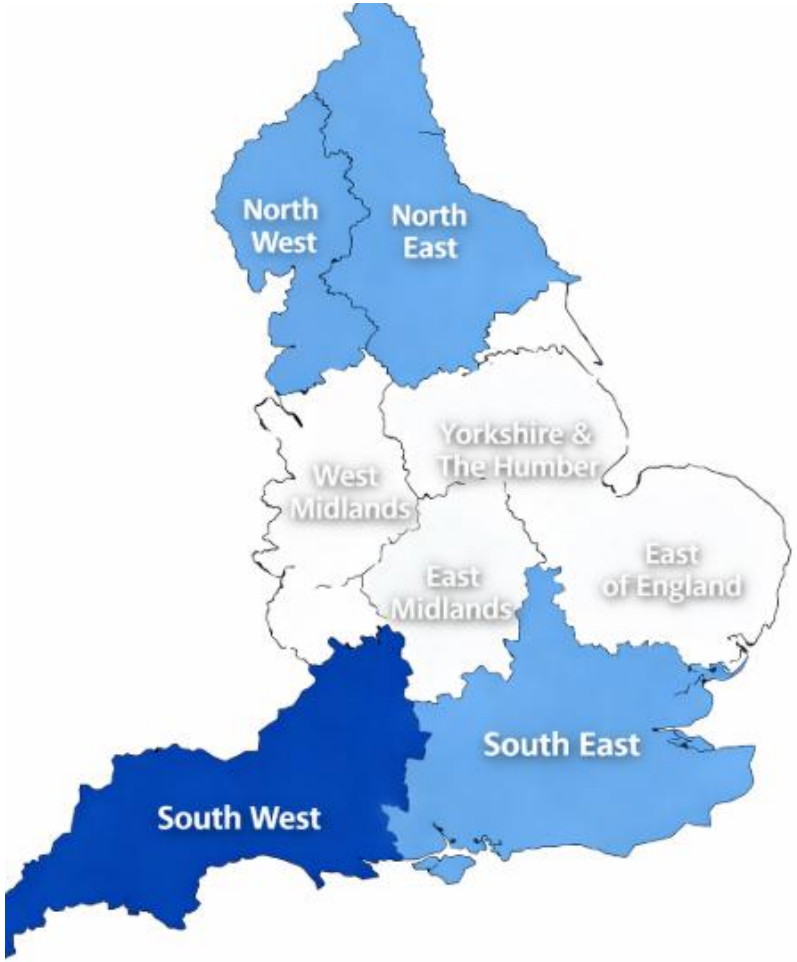




Update on the pilots

- North East
- GMCA

A reminder: we've piloted the placement standard in SW, are rolling out in NE, GM



Already implementing

Currently working to implement

*Note: in North West, 10 GMCA authorities are confirmed part of the pilot; the remaining 14 NW LAs can implement it optionally for now (with intention to roll out more widely in the Summer/Autumn

Update on standard implementation by the North East Region

How we got here:

- A dedicated regional programme of work, which included a previous ‘foundational’ piece of regional data collection focused on sufficiency and a Regional Sufficiency Statement - moving towards a world of RCCs
- Strong region-wide networks and positive precedents for regional working
- Intention to implement something similar given direction of travel and great timing

What's been easier than you might have expected?

- DCS buy-in
- Information governance discussions / joint working
- Bringing together data, finance, strategic and IG leads for group discussions

What's been more difficult than you might have expected?

- Cost breakdown data was not on the original data standard
- Finalising a contract for regional support team in the hosted LA
- LAs updating their internal teams around the project

What are we planning to do with the data?

- Understanding the true needs of our children and young people, and the true cost of care in our region
- Insight dashboards
- Forecasting
- A regional data platform

Update on standard implementation by GMCA

Update on standard implementation, by GM

How we got here:
Greater Manchester CLASP tool (CLA Sufficiency Planning tool) for commissioners
Regional Care Cooperative data platform: linked child-level care and commissioning history data.

Why we joined the pilot?

- To address our data gaps on child need and service type required:
  - To what extent do placements meet child need? Do we have sufficient local provision to meet child need?
  - Does being placed in (un)suitable provision, affect a child's trajectory in care and associated expenditure?

What are we planning to do with the data?

- Child-level data linkage to our existing regional dataset. In future, link this to: NHS data (GP and mental health service), Child in Need Census, Targeted Early Help data.
- To inform: (i) strategy, service and business case development, (ii) market shaping

Open design considerations from last time

Placement specification in its current form, endorsed by this WG

Describes what we think determines whether a placement is offered					Describes actual placement	
Identifying child	Placement Requirements		Placement Recommendation	Risks	Actual Placement	Quality assurance checks
Child ID	Communication Needs	Can child live with pets?	Foster care suitability	Risks to child	Total weekly fee	Referral Officer Name
By when placement is needed	Home Adaptations	Additional Support	Residential care suitability	Risks to others and to property	Location (free text)	Referral Date
Preferred location	Cultural Needs	Deprivation of Liberty	Supported Accommodation suitability		Education continuity	Placement Officer Name
Number of siblings	Living Companions		Min adult support ratio		Provider URN	Placement Date
					Siblings placed together	Officer's name entering cost data
					Actual placement type	Date of cost entered

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					Siblings placed together	Officer's name entering cost data
					Actual placement type	Date of cost entered

Last working group, we agreed that there were four key outstanding design issues: **describing cost, describing preferred location, understanding how commissioners use the data, and developing a strong QA approach.**

Placement specification in its current form, endorsed by this WG

Describes what we think determines whether a placement is offered					Describes actual placement	
Identifying child	**Placement Requirements**		**Placement Recommendation**	**Risks**	**Actual Placement**	**Quality assurance checks**
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Number of siblings	Living Companions		Min adult support ratio		Provider URN	Placement Date
					Siblings placed together	Officer's name entering cost data
					Actual placement type	Date of cost entered

On cost: *as an emerging learning from the North East implementation, we have posted a solution on GitHub. We will hold a deep dive on this and bring it back to the Working Group for endorsement.*

Placement specification in its current form, endorsed by this WG

Describes what we think determines whether a placement is offered					Describes actual placement	
Identifying child	**Placement Requirements**		**Placement Recommendation**	**Risks**	**Actual Placement**	**Quality assurance checks**
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Number of siblings	Companions		Min adult support ratio		Provider URN	Placement Date
					Siblings placed together	Officer's name entering cost data
					Actual placement type	Date of cost entered

On preferred location: *Based on last year's WG discussions we have removed the free text field and added the in/out LA field and the education continuity field. Alongside this we have also added a was it the preferred location' field.*

**We are still keen to do the pilot with London on how to capture this in urban areas and bring the learnings back to the WG*

Placement specification in its current form, endorsed by this WG

Describes what we think determines whether a placement is offered					Describes actual placement	
Identifying child	**Placement Requirements**		**Placement Recommendation**	**Risks**	**Actual Placement**	**Quality assurance checks**
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					Siblings placed together	Officer's name entering cost data
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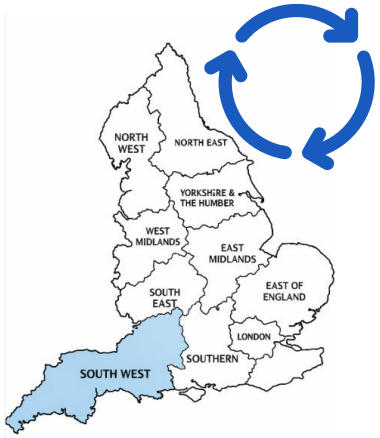
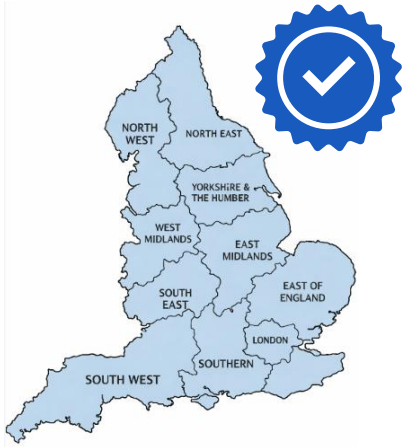
On Quality Assurance: *We are working with Durham as a part of the NE Implementation to understand more about this and are awaiting the first data return due on 13 April. We will schedule a deep dive and bring any proposed decisions back to the Working Group for adoption.*

To summarise..

Existing Open Design Issue	Provisional resolution	Next Steps
Describing Cost	Solution shared on GitHub (splitting the cost into Core, Additional, Education, and Other).	**To schedule a deep dive**
Describing preferred location	Removed free text field. Added additional fields on preferred location being in/out of LA and added another field on education continuity.	**Pilot with London to understand the urban vs rural capture**
Quality Assurance	Working with NE; awaiting the first data return due on 13 April. We will schedule a deep dive and bring any proposed decisions back to the Working Group for adoption.	**To schedule a deep dive**
Commissioners using data	Working with NE on development of the dashboard; awaiting first data return due on 13th April that will provide more insights on how commissioners want to use the data regionally and locally.	**To schedule a deep dive**

2026 Terms of Reference

The terms of reference in 2025 were to design and launch the first standard

2025	2026
	
Our WG terms of reference during this phase were to **design and launch** the first version of the standard	Now in 2026 the role of this WG will shift from design to overseeing **scaling** and maintaining **fidelity** of the live standard

In 2026 this WG's terms of reference will be as follows

2025	2026
	Oversee the rollout to new regions
Our WG terms of reference during this phase were to **design and launch** the first version of the standard	Oversee any changes or updates to the standard
	Champion ongoing standard rollout
	Department for Education Make recommendations about standard governance to DFE

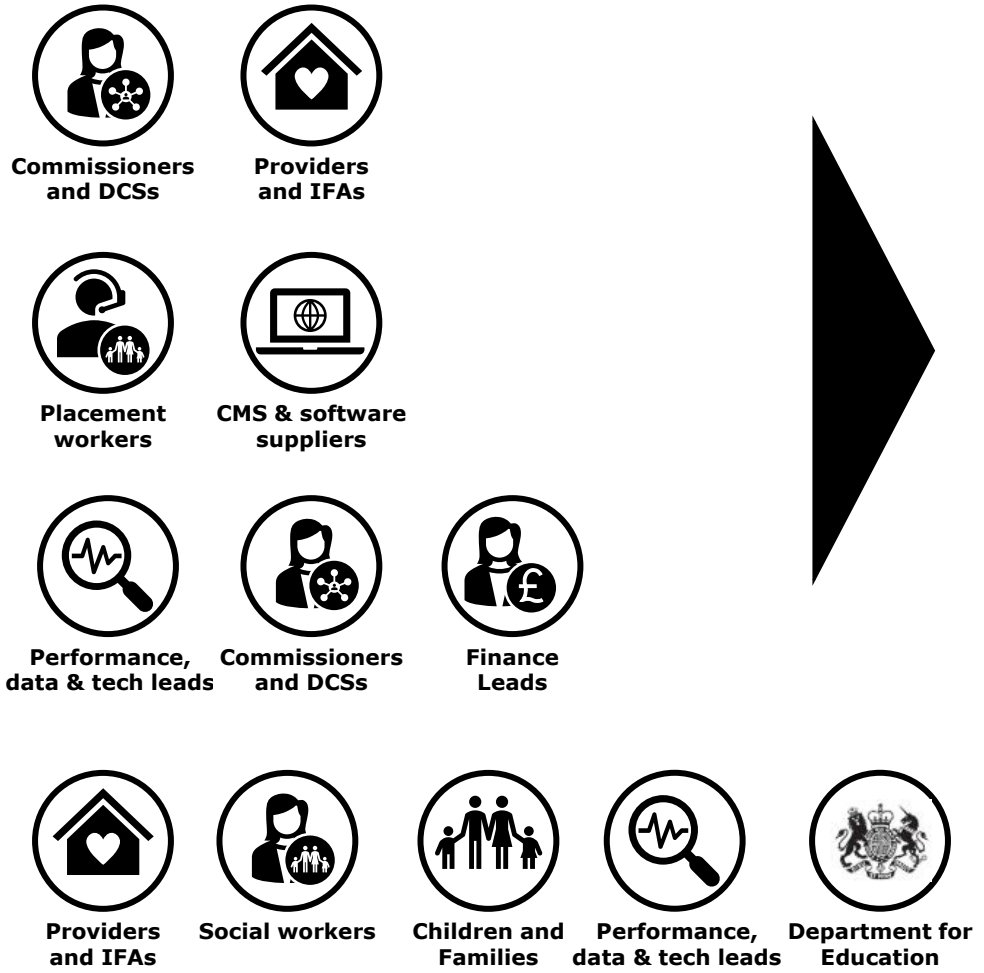
We'll also introduce a new stakeholder perspective lens to our decision making

SCOPE
Does it help us answer key sufficiency questions?

FEASIBILTY
Can it be gathered in <90 seconds without requiring change from CMS vendors?

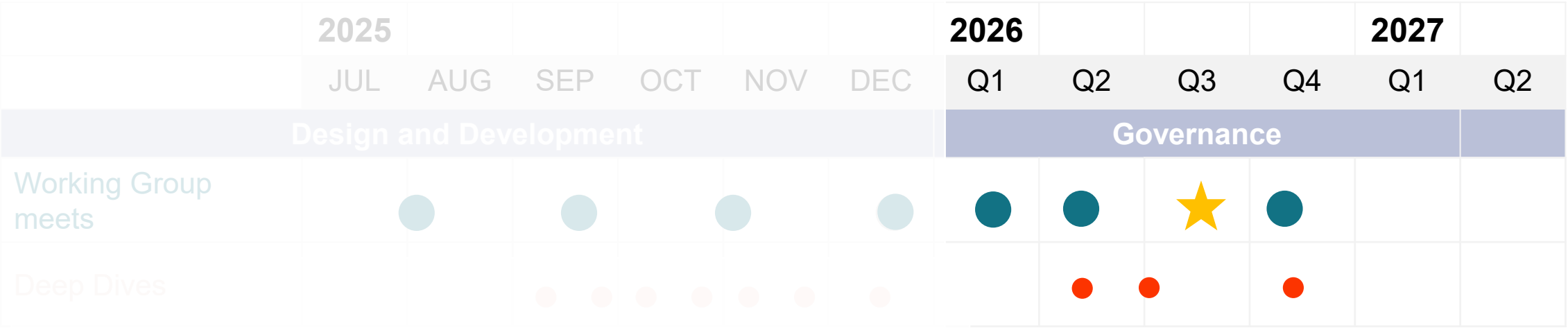
ADDITIONALITY
Are we sure we're not duplicating existing data?

OTHER IMPACTS
Are we sure there are no unintended impacts?



Pilot regions

In terms of meetings, we will follow the same structure

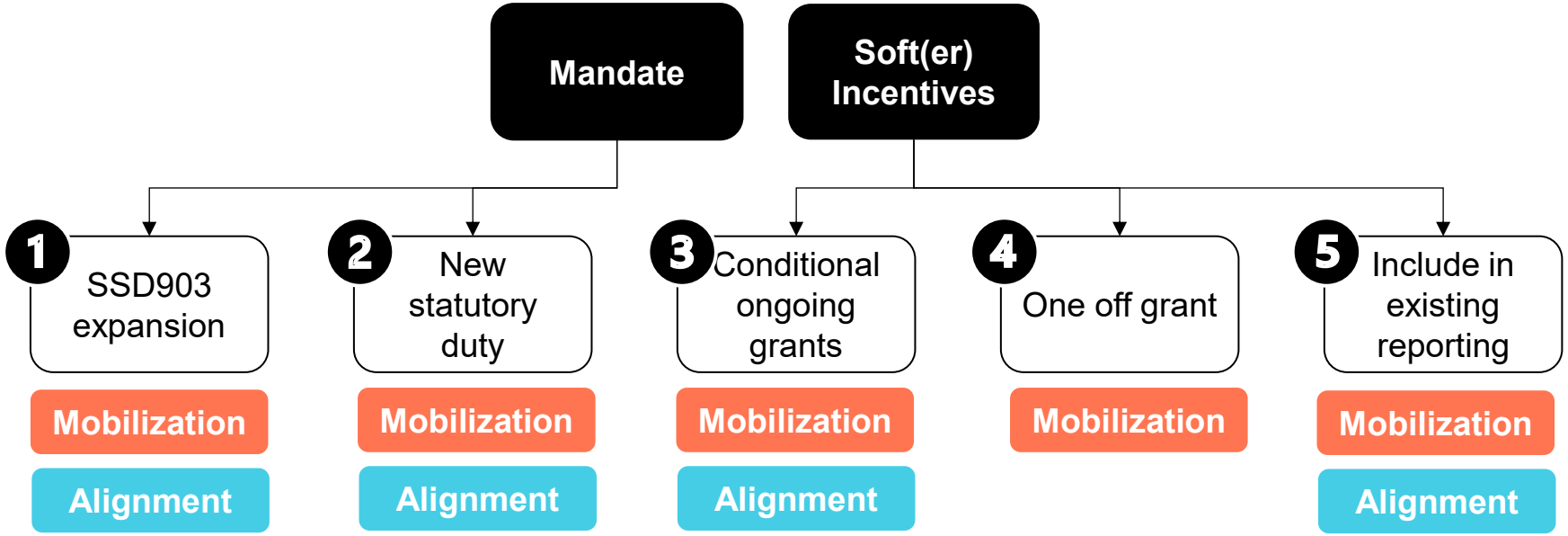


Going forward, we will retain the structure

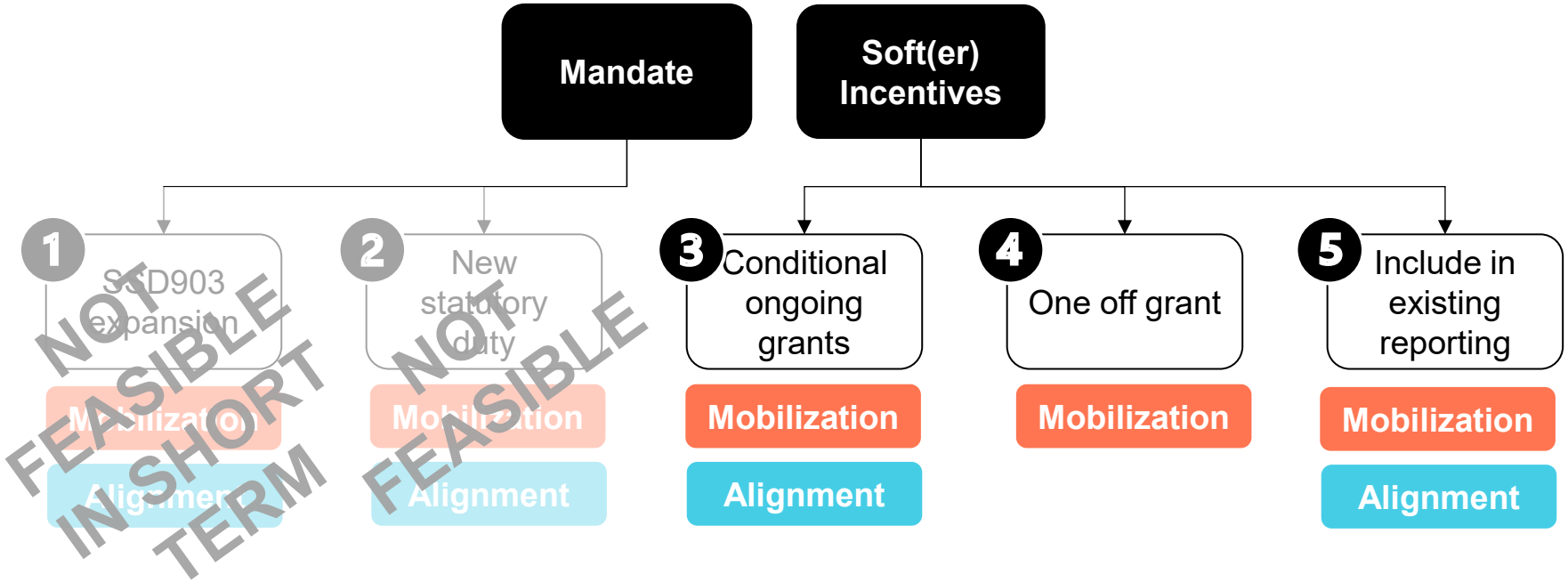
- Quarterly full group meetings to share updates and/endorse key decisions
- Deep Dives as needed for any detailed discussion on a topic
- Single annual review point

To scale further, there are 2 obstacles: the incentive to mobilise in new sites and the incentive to stay aligned post-mobilsation

There are 5 levers to explore that could potentially encourage **mobilization** *in new sites beyond the pilot areas, and 4 that encourage sites to* **stay aligned**



What will ensure things succeed?



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What will enable us to succeed?

All responses to your question will be shown here

Each response can be up to 200 characters long

Turn on voting to let participants vote for their favorites

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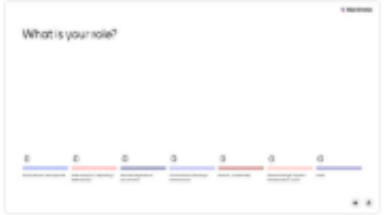

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What obstacles and blind spots do we need to watch out for?

All responses to your question will be shown here

Each response can be up to 200 characters long

Turn on voting to let participants vote for their favorites

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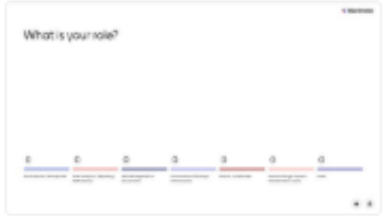
Select which slide to add

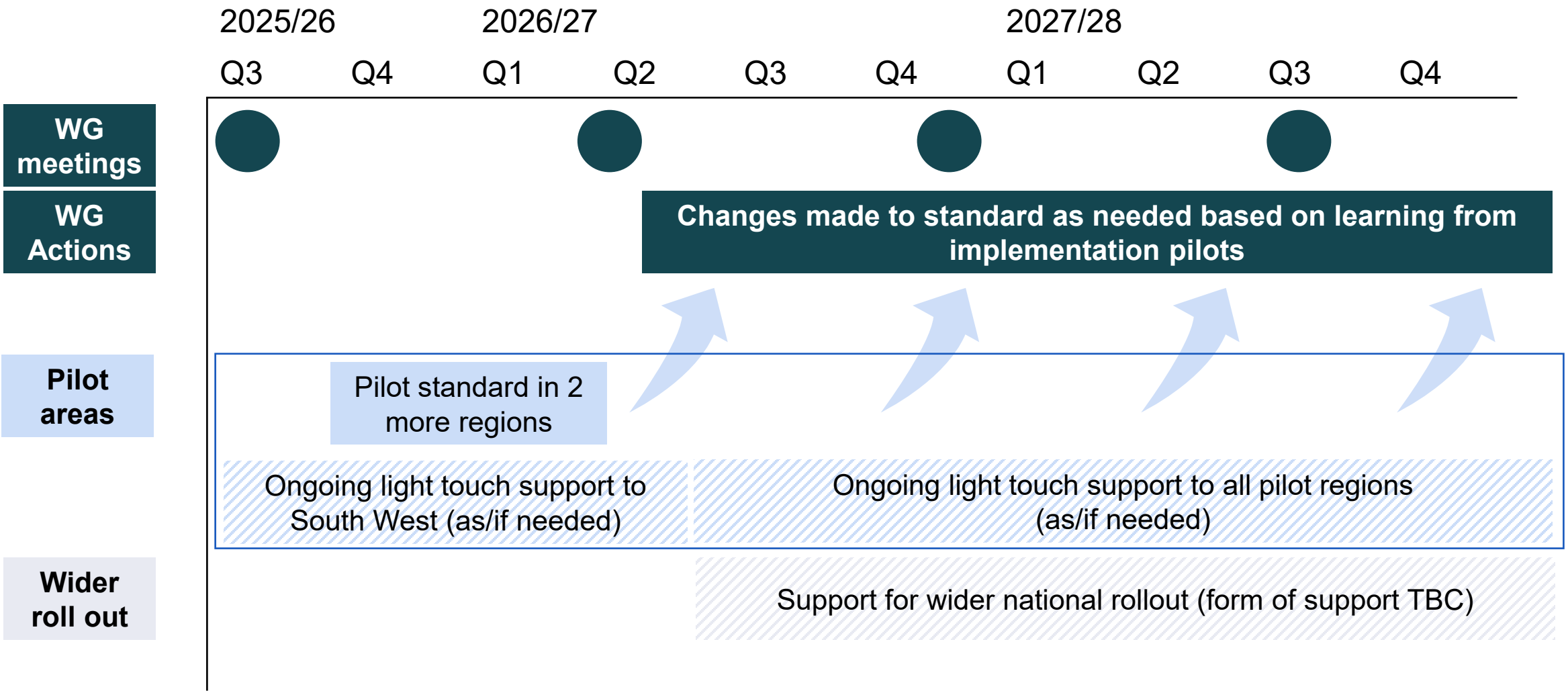


Thank you

Annexure

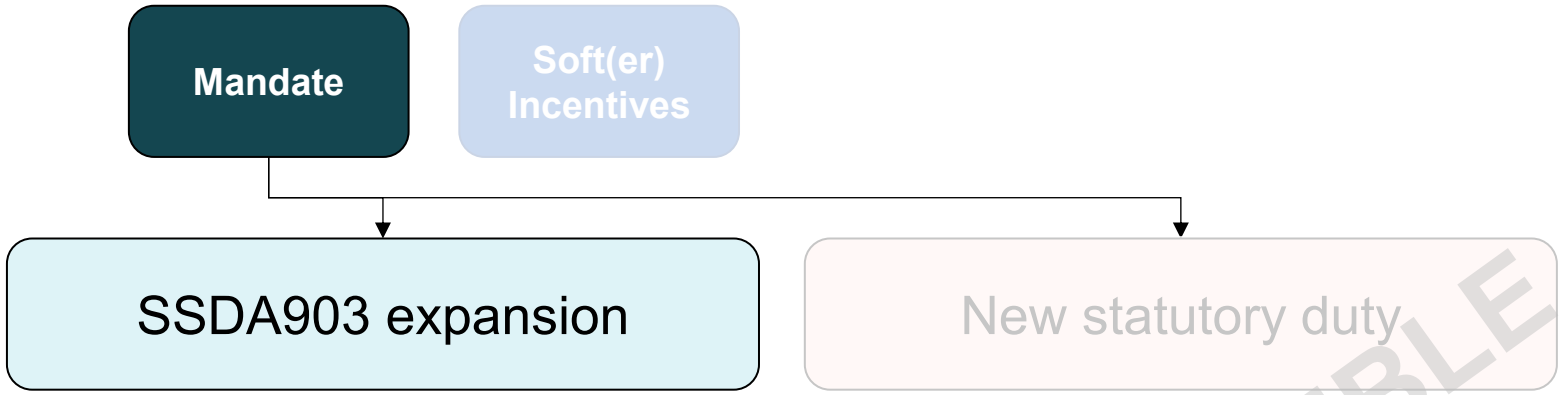
Role of the working group going forward

To update



Next steps

Doing nothing risks losing momentum, but mandation may not be an appropriate or efficient route to sustaining

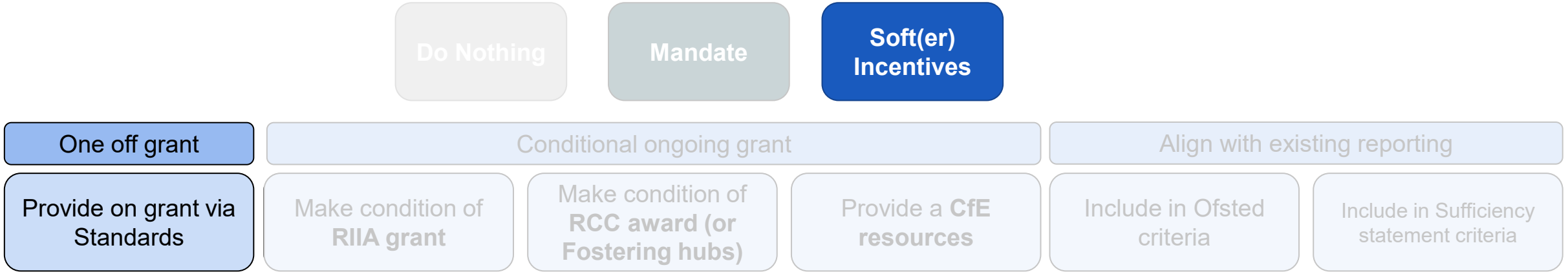


- ✓ Ensures sustainability, quality and scale
- ✗ Min 2 year (likely 3) process (risk losing momentum?)
- ✗ Requires formal consultation, may require ministerial sign off

- ✓ Ensures sustainability, quality and scale
- ✗ Hard (impossible?) to demonstrate placement standard is 'necessary' not 'nice to have'

NOT FEASIBLE

Looking at incentives, one off grants are unlikely to be effective given the lack of ongoing incentive to stay aligned



We should engage policy team to explore alignment with existing grant programmes and consider using CfE grants

Do Nothing | Mandate | **Soft(er) Incentives**

One off grant | Conditional ongoing grant | Align with existing reporting

Provide on grant via Standards

Make condition of **RIIA grant**

- ✓ Ongoing incentive for alignment
- ✓ Covers all regions
- ✓ No new allocation required
- ➢ Policy team to lead

Make condition of **RCC award (or Fostering hubs)**

- ✓ Likely covers all regions
- ✓ Utilised existing grant process
- ➢ Policy team to lead
- × If award not ongoing, incentive to stay aligned weakens

Provide a **CfE resources**

- ✓ In remit of data team
- × Weaker incentive for new adoption
- × Depends on ongoing grant to fund within region

Include in Ofsted criteria

Include in Sufficiency statement criteria

We should also explore alignment existing reporting schemas

Do Nothing | Mandate | **Soft(er) Incentives**

One off grant | Conditional ongoing grant | Align with existing reporting

Provide on grant via Standards | Make condition of RIIA grant | Make condition of RCC award | Provide a CfE grant | Include in Ofsted criteria (point to DfE guidance) | Include in DfE Sufficiency Statement guidance

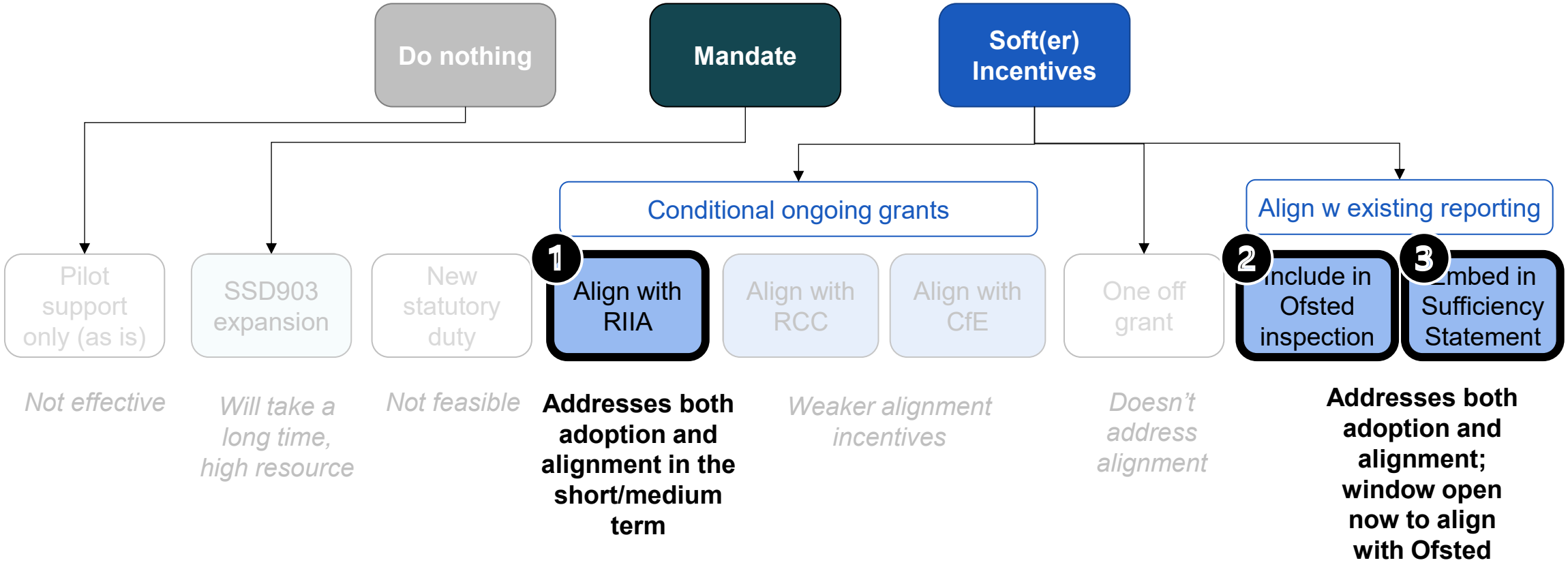
Include in Ofsted criteria (point to DfE guidance)

- ✓ Ongoing incentive for alignment
- ✓ Covers all regions
- ✓ No cost to DfE (?)
- ✓ Ofsted about to renew inspection framework
- ➢ Policy team to lead (?)
- × Requires Ofsted buy in
- × Will take a while?

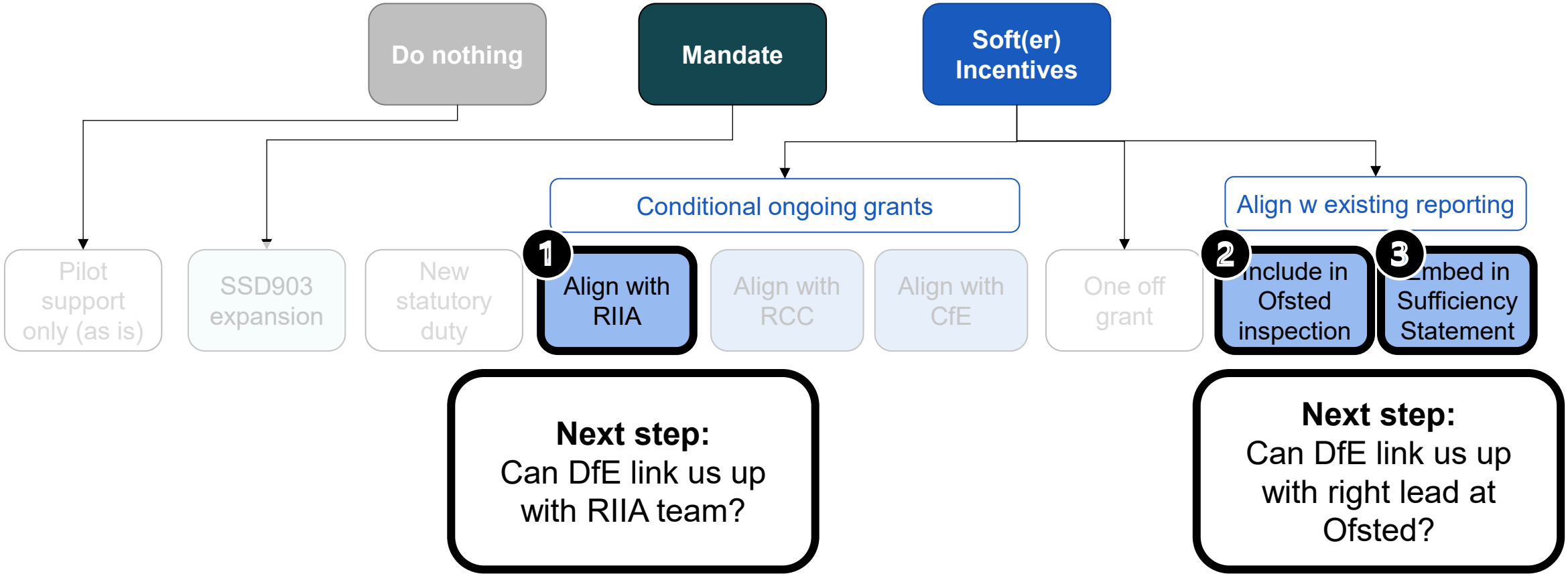
Include in DfE Sufficiency Statement guidance

- ✓ Covers all regions
- ✓ Creates mechanism to maintain standard
- ✓ Nudge toward alignment
- ➢ Policy team to lead
- × DfE can set guidance only, so weak incentive for alignment

3 options stand out as ‘best bets’ – align with RIIA grants and explore including in ILACS and releasing statutory guidance



To progress these options, we need to link up with the right teams at DfE



Where are we up to?

5 Issues resolved in Deep Dives and endorsed by Working Group

RESOLVED:

- ✓ 3 issues related to how we describe the **actual placement**
- ✓ 2 issues how we describe **placement requirements** and child needs

Resolved in Deep Dives; with Working Group today for endorsement

- Describing **placement cost**
- Describing preferred and actual **location**
- **Implementation** approach

Issues to keep 'open' through next implementation phase

- **Engaging providers** to test our approach
- Describing and capturing **cost**
- Describing preferred **location**
- Learning how **commissioners** use the data
- Best approach to **QA**

Reminder: proposed objectives for Placement Standard workstream

So that…

1. **Standard Dramatically Improves Sufficiency Analysis**

   LAs can answer: **what type of provision is needed where and in what volumes**? And what is the business case for doing it in each LA (or in partnership)?

2. **Standard Is Easy to Adopt**

   Placements teams can **enter the data in 90 seconds** or less

3. **Implementation Support is Effective and Affordable**

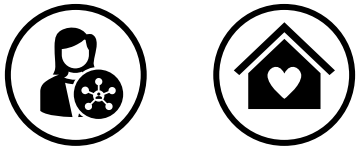
   LAs are able to implement and **benefit from a new standard quickly** within existing resource

Process for reaching resolving each design issue

1. Working Group invited to **build out the 'long list'** of deep dive issues
2. Programme team gathers and **consolidates all comments** raised on each issue, ensuring input from all key perpsectives
4. Attendees at **Deep Dive reach position** to feed back to wider Working Group
3. If there is consensus, **Working Group endorses** and recommends to Steering Committee
5. **Standard remains open** on Github for comments (to review standard periodically)

For each decision, we're testing our thinking against these criteria & perspectives

SCOPE
Does it help us answer key sufficiency questions?



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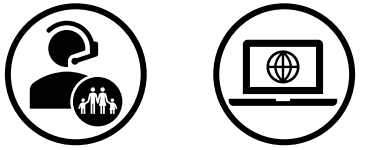

ADDITIONALITY
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OTHER IMPACTS
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Where are we up to?

5 Issues resolved in Deep Dives and endorsed by Working Group

RESOLVED:

- ✓ 3 issues related to how we describe the **actual placement**
- ✓ 2 issues how we describe **placement requirements** and child needs

Resolved in Deep Dives; with Working Group today for endorsement

- Describing **placement cost**
- Describing preferred and actual **location**
- **Implementation** approach

Issues to keep 'open' through next implementation phase

- **Engaging providers** to test our approach
- Describing and capturing **cost**
- Describing preferred **location**
- Learning how **commissioners** use the data
- Best approach to **QA**

Decision – describing placement cost

Issue	Perspectives consulted	Issue raised in deep dives and SW pilot	Resolution
Describing the cost of a placement	Commissioners and DCSs Providers and IFAs Placement workers CMS & software suppliers Finance Leads	• Accuracy of the data likely to be highly sensitive to when it is gathered • Hard to distinguish 'core' from 'total' fee as high degree of variability in the way this is recorded	• **Use an already-validated cost data approach** (PNW) that defines cost as 'total weekly fee' and is gathered quarterly • **Keep issue 'open'** and review based on pilot learning • **Run a small study** to understand data variation in more depth

Decision – describing location

Issue	Perspectives consulted	Issue raised in deep dives and SW pilot	Resolution agreed
Describing preferred location	Commissioners and DCSs Performance, data & tech leads Placement workers CMS & software suppliers	• Free-text likely to hinder analytical insight • Pre-determined list of geographies risks being either too high level or too detailed to be accurate or knowable	• **Use Excel lookup** to allow copy pasting regions from a custom predefined list • **Keep issue open** to review what level of geographic specificity is most suitable

Implementation approach

	Upfront	*Ongoing*
To *adopt the standard*, LAs need:	➢ Strong DCS sponsorship ➢ Accountable lead (c. 1-3 days to update trackers) ➢ IT team to support software changes if needed (e.g. CMS workflow/forms)	➢ *<90 seconds data entry per placement* ➢ *Monthly data QA by accountable lead*
To *enable LAs*, regions need:	➢ DCS champion/s ➢ Regional hub to coordinate ➢ Implementation support to LAs (c. 0.5 FTE x 6 months) ➢ Person-level DSAs	➢ *Regional data and performance team accountable for QA, process improvement and analysis*

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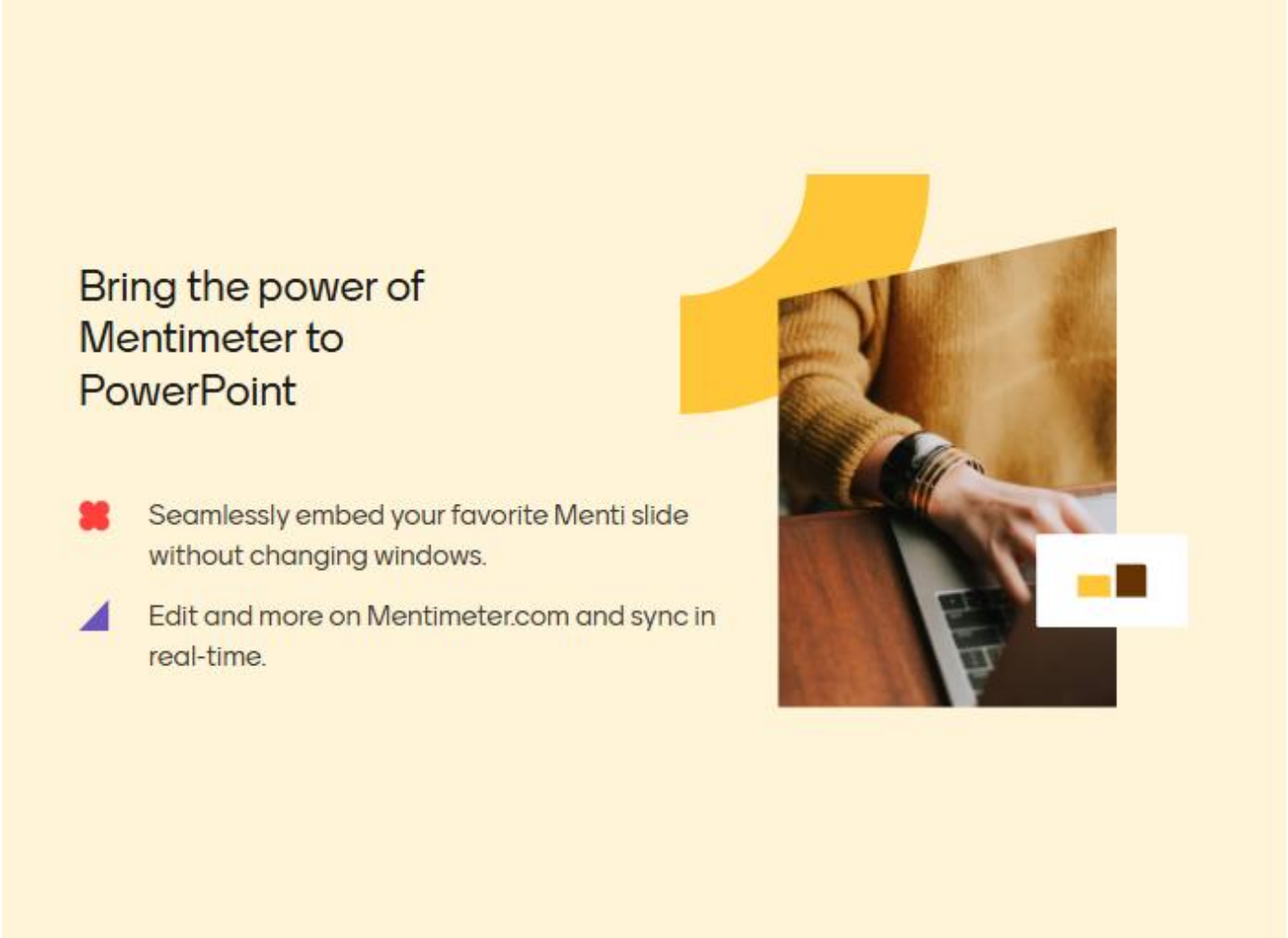

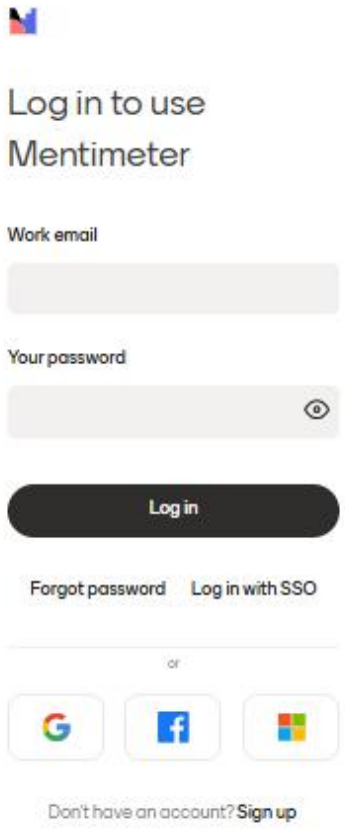

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What next for other standards?

NOW
(decided by Steering Committee)

Better Sufficiency Analysis

NEXT?

- Child need assessments
- eBrokerage
- Better analysis of what could reduce demand
- 'Front door' referrals into CSC
- Embedding child voice
- Child outcomes tracking
- Monitoring fostering supply
- *What else…?*

Considering: *Burden of change on LAs, CMS supplier changes , Need for new tech infrastructure*

Decisions Log – Describing the actual placement

Issue	Resolution agreed	% Working Group accepting resolution
Describing the actual placement	• **Explore further** adding an option to specify top 3 priorities for placement and whether they were achieved to include in a 'silver/gold' version of the standard (rather than in the MVP)	81%
Describing Placement type	• **Add** external / internal distinction • **Explore further** whether we add regulated / unregulated distinction, noting possible practicality constraints	
Describing if siblings were split	• **Change** 'where siblings split' to 'How many siblings were placed together' • **Add** 'Where there was a sibling group, was placement according to plan' with options: 'Yes, No, N/A'	
Describing Placement requirements	• **Drop** 'preferred staffing ratio' • **Change** 'can child live with pets' drop down to 'yes-must, yes-can, no, not known' • **Further test** list of placement requirement determinants of availability with providers.	88%
Describing Risks to child and others	• **Add** DOL (not yet user tested) • **Change** drop down for risks to 'no known risk' / 'risk present' • **Further test** list of risks with providers (e.g. via survey)	

Decisions Log – Describing the actual placement

Issue	Key perspectives	Issue discussed	Resolution agreed
Describing the actual placement	Commissioners and DCSs; Providers and IFAs	• Actual placements described by: Location, Type, Provider URN, and whether siblings were split up • Discussed whether this was the right list for commissioners to understand sufficiency gaps at a high level	• **Explore further** adding an option to specify top 3 priorities for placement and whether they were achieved to include in a 'silver/gold' version of the standard (rather than in the MVP)
Describing Placement type	Commissioners and DCSs; Providers and IFAs; Performance, data & tech leads; Placement workers	• Placement type described by list: Foster, Residential, Supported Accommodation. • Is this list sufficient for commissioners to understand gap between ideal and actual placement type?	• **Add** external / internal distinction • **Explore further** whether we add regulated / unregulated distinction, noting possible practicality constraints
Describing if siblings were split	Commissioners and DCSs; Placement workers; Children & Family Voice	• Whether siblings were split is described by options: Y/N • Is the description of whether siblings were split up (a) able to be gathered by placement workers and (b) granular enough to be useful?	• **Change** 'where siblings split' to 'How many siblings were placed together' • **Add** 'Where there was a sibling group, was placement according to plan' with options: 'Yes, No, N/A'

Decisions Log – Describing what determines placement availability

Issue	Key perspectives	Issue discussed	Resolution agreed
Describing Placement requirements	Commissioners and DCSs; Placement workers; Performance, data & tech leads; Providers and IFAs	• This section captures what providers told us in initial testing what matters most when deciding to offer placement • Is it this list (a) practical for a placement worker to gather this information and (b) sufficiently nuanced for commissioners to understand drivers of placement availability	• **Drop** 'preferred staffing ratio' • **Change** 'can child live with pets' drop down to 'yes-must, yes-can, no, not known' • **Further test** list of placement requirement determinants of availability with providers.
Describing Risks to child and others	Commissioners and DCSs; Placement workers; Performance, data & tech leads; Providers and IFAs	• This section captures what providers told us in initial testing what matters most when deciding to offer placement • Is it this list (a) practical for a placement worker to gather this information and (b) sufficiently nuanced for commissioners to understand drivers of placement availability	• **Add** DOL (not yet user tested) • **Change** drop down for risks to 'no known risk' / 'risk present' • **Further test** list of risks with providers (e.g. via survey)

Decision – describing location

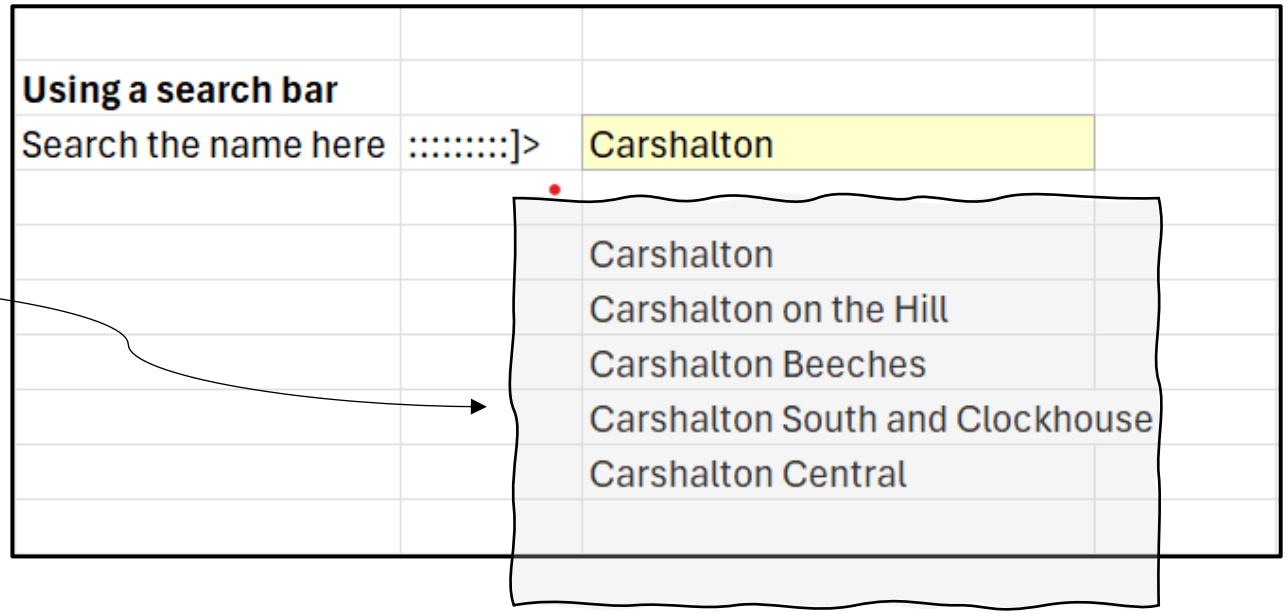
How do we meaningfully capture a child's preferred placement location?

Solutions we tried	Challenges identified through Deep Dives
❑ Open text box to describe child's preferred area	• Inconsistent entries ("near school," "Somerset," "Bath area") • Limits analytical use. • Time consuming to clean
❑ Capturing postcode	• Placement officers may not have or know it at the matching stage • Time consuming and error prone entry • Incomplete data risk
Resolution adopted	
❑ Excel lookup with predefined region names.	• Easier and faster for placement team searching with names of places, consistent format for analysis, • Next focus will to be finding the right level of geographic specificity.
❑ Field to sense check location from the placement offc.	• Adding a separate sense check field – was the actual location the child's preferred area? provides additional accuracy
❑ Mapping education continuity	• Added field on education continuity to provide further nuance around whether the placement was preferred, all else equal, and in line with suggestions raised during deep dive discussion about the importance of educational continuity (in many, but not all placements)

Decision – describing location

Excel lookup function for Preferred Location

1. A separate search bar to enter the region name
2. Based on the search bar a list of regions appears.
3. Placement officer can copy and paste the region in the referral form



Advantages

- Easier and faster for placement team searching with names of places over postcodes
- Consistent format for analysis